Daily wage workers were perhaps the hardest hit by demonetization. Subsisting at the bottom of the pyramid, with no savings, no job protection, and no certainty of where the next meal would come from, the note ban was a devastating blow.

Millions of workers in the informal sector lost their jobs as employers, faced with a cash crunch, laid them off. Those who managed to find alternative work were forced to either accept old notes and then spend hours in queues to exchange them, or work on credit in anticipation of a future payment. Reduced to starvation and destitution, the stories below are illustrative of the havoc demonetization wreaked on their lives.

- Sharda Jhala, a farm labourer from Aravalli district, stares at an uncertain future. Work has dried up after demonetization, and she has had work for barely 20 days at half wages of ₹100 per day. 'My husband can't work, and I am the sole breadwinner of the family,' says Sharda. 'I had taken a loan recently to buy a cow. With livelihood becoming uncertain, I've cut the food even for the animal…We eat once a day with the resources we have – bajra (pearl millet) and onion or chilli. I hope the situation improves, or else we will be forced to starve.'[8]
- Munna Singh, a porter at the Azadpur mandi in Delhi, spends his day loading and offloading vegetables and fruits from trucks which come to the mandi. 'If it is a good day at the mandi, I make anything between ₹700–1,000. On a bad day, my earnings are never less than ₹500. But I am struggling to get even ₹100 now. It is not as if I did not work at all. But everyone wants to pay me in old notes. Some traders for whom I worked last week have promised that I will be paid later,' said Singh.[9]
- Basanti Marandi hails from the northern district of Mayurbhanj in Odisha and makes a living as a daily wage labourer. 'I don't know if I am to get work today because labour contractors don't hire many labourers for their work since the government has